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Bernard Lonergan

Consciousness as Experience and Operation

LONERGAN'S MAJOR philosophical work, *Insight*, contains a passage that sounds very like something that might have been said by Polanyi: "The simple fact is that a man cannot reconstruct his mind by the process of explicit analysis; for explicit analysis takes more time than the spontaneous procedures of the mind; it has taken each of us our lifetime to reach by spontaneous procedures the mentalities we now possess; and so if it were necessary for us to submit our mentalities to a total explicit analysis, it would also be necessary for us to have twofold lives, a life to live, and another longer life in which to analyse the life that is lived" (pp. 716–17). The similarity is clear, but the same passage also implies some significant differences between the two thinkers. Lonergan agrees with Polanyi in principle about our inability to render all of our knowing explicit at a given time. What he is referring to in the passage quoted, however, is, within its context, rather more specific: the fact that each of our thoughts is founded on layers of accumulated beliefs that it would be impracticable to review one by one. This is a fact that does not preclude the possibility that any particular item of implicit belief could be rendered explicit and checked for accuracy if the effort were made. Polanyi used his concept of the tacit dimension to encompass everything in consciousness that at any moment was implicit, some of which might be capable of explication and some of which could not. One characteristic difference between the two thinkers which is exemplified in this case lies in the greater specificity of Lonergan's thought—its reference to judgments of truth rather than to all the steps and

elements of implicit thought process and its clarity regarding what in particular he thinks must remain implicit and why.

A more important place, however, to look for the similarity as well as the difference between Polanyi and Lonergan is in their ways of interpreting the phenomenon both take as the starting point of their reflection: the fact of inquiry. Both, for example, have discussed the problem presented in Plato's *Meno*: how can we seek knowledge of something unless in some way we already know it. What is hidden and yet questionable constitutes for Lonergan a "known unknown," something of which we cannot yet give an explicit account but about which we nevertheless know enough to ask questions.¹ Polanyi speaks similarly in *The Tacit Dimension* when he says, "The kind of tacit knowledge that solves the paradox of the *Meno* consists in the intimation of something hidden, which we may yet discover" (pp. 22–23). Explaining what he means, however, Polanyi suggests an approach that itself raises more questions than it answers. He says that "the *Meno* shows conclusively that if all knowledge is explicit, i.e., capable of being clearly stated, then we cannot know a problem or look for its solution" (p. 22). Quite apart from whether Plato could really be said to have proved Polanyi's theory of tacit knowing, one might reasonably wonder, as was suggested at the end of the last chapter, whether the word "know" can have the same meaning when referring to tacit inklings and to considered judgments of truth. Polanyi's analysis did not probe that question, but Lonergan's does.

Lonergan's answer is that it is necessary to differentiate two distinct conceptions of knowing: that which is simply an apprehension of experiential data and that which is the fruit of understanding and critical reflection. That which is prior to explicit understanding and reflective judgment Lonergan does not consider to constitute knowledge in the full and proper sense of the term. It is conscious, but within the field of consciousness Lonergan distinguishes between experience in the strict sense, which is simple awareness of experiential data, a mere starting point for inquiry, on the one hand, and knowledge in the proper sense on the other. Experience may or may not be understood. When it is understood, the correctness of the understanding may be questioned, and when correctness is determined, one has "knowledge" in the sense in

1. See, for example, *Insight*, p. 546.

which Lonergan uses the term. Knowledge in the proper sense, that is, is consciously correct understanding, and its object alone is what can properly be called reality. "The real," says Lonergan, "is the verified; it is what is to be known by the knowing constituted by experience and inquiry, insight and hypothesis, reflection and verification" (*Insight*, p. 252). He goes on to say, however, that "besides knowing in that rather complex sense, there is also 'knowing' in the elementary sense in which kittens know the 'reality' of milk. . . . Both types of knowing possess their validity. One cannot claim that one is concerned with mere appearance while the other is concerned with reality. For elementary knowing vindicates its validity by the survival, not to mention the evolution of the animal species. On the other hand, any attempt to dispute the validity of fully human knowing involves the use of that knowing. . . ." Experience may be noticed and attended to, but only when it is interpreted and the interpretation is verified does it constitute the substratum of knowledge in the proper or critical sense.

Polanyi and Lonergan do not disagree on this point, but Lonergan has gone further than Polanyi did in developing a precise technical terminology for it and working out in detail the implications of the break it represents with the empiricist conception of knowledge, according to which the most incontestably genuine knowledge of which we are capable is the sort we have of sense data and in which the only active role the knower has to play is that of an attentive observer.

One of the more dramatic and revealing statements Lonergan has made about the history of philosophy appears on page 372 of *Insight*, where he says: "Five hundred years separate Hegel from Scotus. . . . that notable interval of time was largely devoted to working out in a variety of manners the possibilities of the assumption that knowing consists in taking a look. The ultimate conclusion was that it did not and could not." This statement indicates Lonergan's own situation within this history as one whose philosophical roots lie in thinkers both earlier and later than that episode and who considers himself to be working out the implications of the realization that knowing is much more than a look, that it cannot be a primarily passive process in which an object impresses itself or its image on an observer.

When Lonergan said that the ultimate conclusion of the five hundred year test of the theory of passive cognition was that it did not hold up, he was not speaking for many thinkers, and even those who would ac-

cept the same conclusion have found it difficult to apply its implications consistently. He was, however, speaking for some, among whom the philosophers discussed in this study are prominent; and when he designated Hegel as the historically epochal figure in the modern movement away from passivist epistemology, he showed a sound appreciation of Hegel's role as well as of the main tenor of his thought.

Hegel has been widely misinterpreted. For example, Hegel's supposed dialectic of thesis and antithesis culminating virtually mechanically in a synthesis is simply a myth; as Walter Kaufmann has convincingly shown, it is not to be found in Hegel's writings.² What was genuinely central to Hegel's thought was the idea that all knowing involves a relation between subjective and objective poles in the cognitive act. This was, in effect, a return to something more like the Aristotelian conception, according to which knowing always involves some active involvement on the part of the subject and a formal union or isomorphism between subject and object.³ Kaufmann cites a passage from the preface to Hegel's *Logic* that makes clear the classical roots of Hegel's thought and that also finds echoes subsequently in the work of Lonergan: "... ancient metaphysics had ... a higher concept of thinking than has become prevalent in recent times. For it assumed that what in things is recognized by thinking is what alone in them is truly true; thus not they in their immediacy, but only they as lifted into the form of thinking, as thought. This metaphysics thus held that thinking and the determinations of thought were not alien to objects but rather their essence, or that *things* and the *thinking* of them ... agree in and for themselves."⁴

Implicit in this way of thinking are three principles that are also fundamental to Lonergan's thought: (1) knowing is an active process; (2) this process results in a commonness of structure between the subjective and objective poles of the process; and (3) this formal identity of structure unites the knower with the known.

These assumptions were shared by Polanyi as well, but Lonergan goes much further in drawing out their implications. To read Polanyi is for the most part to remain fairly comfortably situated within the world

2. Hegel: *A Reinterpretation*. See, for example, p. 161. The actual source of the tripartite schematism, says Kaufmann, was Fichte.

3. Cf. Aristotle, *On the Soul*, bk. 3, ch. 8: 431b, 20–28; cf. also Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, I, q. 14, a. 2.

4. 1812 edition, p. v; 1841 edition, p. 27; quoted in Kaufmann, *Hegel*, p. 179.

of common sense, where it is still easy to imagine a clear division between subject and object in something like spatial terms. Polanyi, as we saw, does correlate “inner” and “outer” with subsidiary and focal modes of awareness rather than with spatial location, but to explain those concepts he tends to use images of visual perception (of probing a cavity, looking through a stereopticon, and so on) that reinforce us in our habit of assimilating theoretical conceptions to the imaginatively familiar world of sensory perception—to that world, that is, in which the real is what is supposedly “out there” and is to be known by “taking a look.”⁵

Lonerган, however, presses his discussion forward completely into the realm of theory. This demands both a refinement of language to technically precise meanings and a radical break with the imagination. The imagination is rooted immediately in the data of experience and constitutes an initial and rudimentary step toward form; the form it discovers, however, is only an experiential pattern, and no matter how “real” or “meaningful” it might feel, it is neither critically grounded nor fully intelligible. It is a great challenge to make the break with imagination that Lonergan believed is demanded if one is to take adequately into account all the implications of developed theoretical thinking, a demand that is becoming increasingly insistent as theoretical inquiry proceeds in the various sciences.

The prevailing paradigm of knowledge until recently was perceptualist: it was assumed that all genuine knowing took place by clear and accurate observation. But for modern science this is no longer tenable. Heinz Pagels, in his history of the development of quantum physics, stated the issue in almost precisely these terms: “As Max Born put it, ‘The generation to which Einstein, Bohr and I belong was taught that there exists an objective physical world, which unfolds itself according to immutable laws independent of us; we are watching this process as the audience watches a play in a theater.’ . . . But with the quantum theory, human intention influences the structure of the physical world.”⁶ Lonergan himself would probably state the last point slightly differently, since the idea of “influence” still connotes the image of an

5. Cf. Lonergan on what he considered the fallacy of the “already, out, there, now, real,” *Insight*, pp. 251–52.

6. *The Cosmic Code: Quantum Physics as the Language of Nature*, p. 95.

already constituted external object that is altered by our observation of it. To say that would be to assume that reality in the proper sense is to be found on the level not of the interpreted and critically verified but of the datum. Lonergan's own way of putting the point would be to say that the object as datum is simply experiential and that only as an element of the known or potentially knowable can it meaningfully be said to be real. The major problem for human reflection, from this point of view, is to break out of the hold that uncritical images have on our attempts at understanding. As Lonergan put it in the introduction to *Insight*, "Even before Einstein and Heisenberg it was clear enough that the world described by scientists was strangely different from the world depicted by artists and inhabited by men of common sense. But it was left to twentieth-century physicists to envisage the possibility that the objects of their science were to be reached only by severing the umbilical cord that tied them to the maternal imagination of man" (p. xxi).

Polanyi would not disagree. On the contrary, he was as convinced as Lonergan that the real in the strict sense is what is known through an act of critical intelligence rather than through sensation or imagination. This was why, as was mentioned in the last chapter, he considered a strictly theoretical conception of space ("a super-Copernican vision, totally at variance with our habitual experience") to be such an important advance on the absolute space of Newton, as "a theory grounded in reason and transcending the senses" (*Personal Knowledge*, p. 12). Polanyi was as fully committed as Lonergan to a consistently theoretical conception of the real, although his way of expressing himself sounded less forbiddingly austere, which may be one reason for his comparatively wider readership.

The perceptualist paradigm of knowing was perhaps the most fundamental assumption of the philosophical epoch of which Hegel marked the close. Although this framework of thought was not born with the late Middle Ages, but had always been the attitude of extraverted common sense, it took on a more theoretical character among thinkers of that period. It eventually became a major presupposition linking such disparate figures as Scotus, Ockham, Descartes, Locke, and Kant.⁷ Its

7. For a discussion of Kant in relation to Lonergan, see Giovanni Sala, "The A Priori in Human Knowledge: Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason* and Lonergan's *Insight*," *The Thomist* 40 (1976): 179–221.

characteristic tenet was that the object one knows is a thing “out there,” entirely separate from the individual who knows it; the knower looks over at it across a gap that is both physical and ontological, and if he gives it a good look and nothing distorts his vision, he receives accurate impressions of it. The major problem from the point of view of such an epistemology is, of course, how to be certain the object is really there or that its impressions are accurately transmitted across the gap. The question of certainty became the characteristic preoccupation of the epistemological epoch referred to, and its force is still widely felt by those who continue to share its assumptions. What a thinker of the other pattern looks for is less certainty than rationally grounded confidence, or what John Henry Newman, who was himself a major influence on Lonergan, called “certitude.”⁸

Of course a person convinced of a perceptionist epistemology would ask at this point how one can be certain regarding one’s certitude, but from Newman’s point of view and Lonergan’s, the true ground of intellectual confidence is the knower’s awareness of the basis of his judgment of truth and of the care with which he performs it. As Newman put the matter, “certitude is not a passive impression made upon the mind from without, by argumentative compulsion [or, Lonergan might add, by the perception of an empirical datum], but in all concrete questions . . . it is an active recognition of propositions as true such as it is the duty of each individual himself to exercise at the bidding of reason, and, when reason forbids, to withhold.”⁹ Everyone who wishes to arrive at genuine knowledge, that is, must perform for himself the operations that produce it.

Newman only began the analysis of cognitional process, and his approach was largely descriptive, but in his emphasis on the role of judgment he made a major contribution to the line of thought Lonergan has developed. Hegel gave this function comparatively little attention. As Lonergan stated, “Hegel’s range of vision is enormous; indeed, it is unrestricted in extent. But it is always restricted in content, for it views

8. Regarding Newman, Lonergan has said, “My fundamental mentor and guide has been John Henry Newman’s *Grammar of Assent*,” “Reality, Myth, and Symbol,” in Alan M. Olson, ed., *Myth, Symbol, and Reality*, p. 34. For a general account of the influence of Newman on Lonergan, see George S. Worgul, “The Ghost of Newman in the Lonergan Corpus,” *Modern Schoolman* 54 (1977): 317–32.

9. John Henry Newman, *An Essay in Aid of A Grammar of Assent*, p. 262.

everything as it would be if there were no facts" (*Insight*, p. 373). What Lonergan drew from Hegel, or at least found congenial in him, was his concept of *Aufhebung* (usually translated as "sublation" or "sublimation") and his idea of development in consciousness: "As his *Aufhebung* both rejects and retains, so also in their own fashion do our higher viewpoints. As he repeatedly proceeds from *an sich*, through *für sich*, to *an und für sich*, so our whole argument is a movement from the objects of mathematical, scientific, and common-sense understanding, through the acts of understanding themselves, to an understanding of understanding" (p. 374 n.). Judgment, however, was not Hegel's focus, whereas for Newman it was as central as it subsequently became for Lonergan.

What Newman offered to Lonergan was a starting point for the systematic investigation of human cognitive operations. This inquiry, as Lonergan conceives it, is directed by three basic questions: (1) What are we doing when we are knowing? (2) Why is doing that knowing? (3) What do we know when we do it? The answer to the first, he calls cognitive theory. The answer to the second is epistemology. That to the third is metaphysics.

It is the first that he takes to be most fundamental; we begin with a cognitive process that is already going on and we proceed to an understanding of it by discovering what it is we are engaged in. By attending carefully to our cognitive operations, Lonergan says, we can discover that they fall into three basic categories: attention, understanding, and judgment.

These three operations, according to Lonergan's analysis, are the building blocks of every genuinely cognitive act, and they form an invariant sequence; that is, they build upon one another. The judgment of truth is founded upon an interpretation, and interpretation is founded upon some sort of experience. For Lonergan these terms refer not to objects but to acts: experiencing involves an active attending to data, either of sense or of consciousness; interpreting is a construing of the data in a formal pattern that can relate them to one another; judging is the culmination of a process of reflection regarding the adequacy of a construing to the data it attempts to take into account. What happens in practice is that an initial, relatively passive experience of some datum gives rise to a question, which becomes the moving force of a closer attending and of the further operations of questioning about meaning. As

Plato and Aristotle did before him, Lonergan also believed that the beginning of philosophy lies in the experience of wonder. It is the force of the wondering question that impels one to attempts at interpreting and to reflection upon the adequacy of the interpretation to the data it construes.

The cognitive process culminates, when it is fully accomplished, in a reflective judgment to the effect that the interpretation is sufficiently comprehensive and careful and is at least the best one can think of for the time being. Further questioning, of course, always remains a possibility: additional data may be noticed that will need to be accounted for or new possibilities of interpretation may turn up. This need not impede the definite "yes" or "no" of judgment, however, because even though a judgment may regard an interpretation that is only relatively adequate, the judgment itself may be fully adequate to the extent that it takes the relative into account. If, for example, one were to assess a probability at something above 50 percent, the judgment of truth would not be a declaration that the event in question was certainly going to happen; it would simply declare that as far as the evidence indicates, the event is more likely to happen than not and by some measurable margin. Or, to take another example, if one were to consider the question of the adequacy of Newtonian physics as compared with quantum physics, an eighteenth- or nineteenth-century thinker could have judged quite reasonably that Newton's physics explained with sufficient precision the phenomena one was at that time interested in explaining, and such a judgment would not in itself necessarily imply a belief that no better system of physics would ever be possible. The latter belief would have been unreasonable, but it would have been so not because it referred to what was only relatively adequate, but because it failed to recognize the relativity involved. Judgments are made, and when they are, they necessarily take the form of a Boolean expression: yes or no, true or false. A judgment is always definite, even when it regards the relative.

This is not, of course, to imply that judgments will always be sound. They depend for their own adequacy on the acts of attention and interpretation that underlie them as well as on the sensitivity of intellectual conscience of the inquirer, who may terminate his efforts of investigation too soon or let himself be distracted by other interests than a radical love of truth. Careful judgments can, however, take place, and when they do, says Lonergan, they constitute the only knowledge a human in-

quirer can ever have: that which is constituted by the set of interrelated, cumulative operations he describes.

Lonergan's account of knowing as constituted by the operations of attention, interpretation, and judgment could seem so obviously true as to be trivial, and there is a sense in which this is the case. Any attempt to establish that these three operations play no role in knowing or that any of them could be dispensed with would soon destroy itself by an unintended *reductio ad absurdum*. Lonergan has himself described the implications quite bluntly:

Despite the doubts and denials of positivists and behaviorists, no one, unless some of his organs are deficient, is going to say that never in his life did he have the experience of seeing or of hearing, of touching or smelling or tasting, of imagining or perceiving, of feeling or moving; or that if he appeared to have such experience, still it was mere appearance, since all his life long he has gone about like a somnambulist without any awareness of his own activities. Again, how rare is the man that will preface his lectures by repeating his conviction that never did he have even a fleeting experience of intellectual curiosity, of inquiry, of striving and coming to understand, of expressing what he has grasped by understanding. Rare too is the man that begins his contributions to periodical literature by reminding his potential readers that never in his life did he experience anything that might be called critical reflection, that he never paused about the truth or falsity of any statement, that if ever he seemed to exercise his rationality by passing judgment strictly in accord with the available evidence, then that must be counted mere appearance for he is totally unaware of any such event or even any such tendency.¹⁰

Despite the inherent obviousness of the invariant structured pattern of cognitive operations, there are several reasons why pointing it out is not trivial at all. One is that so many epistemologies have been founded on other assumptions, especially those of perceptionism. Another is that however fundamental the operations may be, they can be easily overlooked in practice (probably the major reason for the popularity of rival epistemologies). Still another is that to apply consistently the principle that what can be known is what we know by performing these opera-

10. *Method in Theology*, pp. 16–17. This work will subsequently be referred to as *Method*.

tions leads to conclusions about our objects of knowledge that conflict with most of our habitual assumptions. The deficiency of perceptionist epistemologies has already been discussed. Let us consider the last two of these points in turn.

A helpful example with which to illustrate both the presence of the three basic operations and the difficulty in practice of noticing them might be a visual figure such as the Fraser Spiral (see Figure 1). This

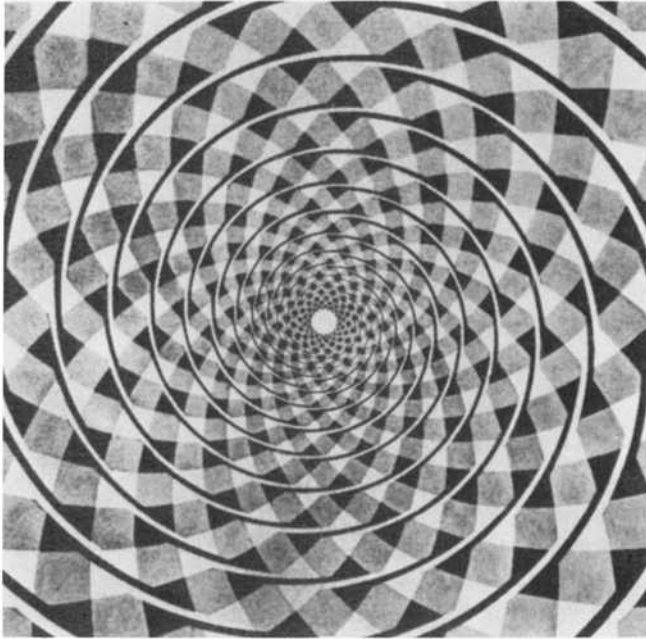


Figure 1. Fraser Spiral

figure is used by Sir Ernst Gombrich in his *Art and Illusion* as an example of what he calls “the etc. principle.”¹ By this term Gombrich refers to the fact that when there are several visual cues of a certain pattern in a picture, the tendency of the beholder is to assume that the pattern is repeated consistently. In this case, the cues suggest convergence

11. *Art and Illusion: A Study in the Psychology of Pictorial Representation*, 5th ed., p. 184.

of the various lines upon the center of the picture, and for this reason we tend to perceive what appears to us to be a striped spiral moving in from the periphery toward the center. In fact, however, although there are various hints at a spiraling pattern, there is no spiral in the picture. To determine this, one can try tracing the apparent spiral with a pencil; one discovers that the pencil always returns to its starting point and that the figure is actually a set of concentric circles. This usually comes as a surprise. If it does, that is because the observer feels convinced that the picture represents a spiral. That feeling of conviction grows out of an unnoticed process of interpretation and uncritical judgment. Gombrich's "etc. principle" refers to the interpretative phase of this process. The feeling of conviction arises from settling uncritically for the nearest interpretation at hand, the one that springs spontaneously to mind. None of this process, of course, is actually conscious, which is to say that it is not noticed or adverted to. The data of the figure—the black, gray, and white markings and their shapes—are noticed, but the interpretative process is not. The operations by which the data of sense in this case are processed and packaged take place within a conscious person, but the person is not conscious of those operations and in fact cannot be said as subject to be performing them; he is conscious only of the data and of the perceptual package that is the product of the process that takes place within his nervous system between the point of sensory stimulus and the finished package. The only operation he can be said to be performing consciously is his attending to the data and to the spiral he believes he sees; in other words, his only consciously intended operations are empirical, not intellectual or rational.

To put the matter in Polanyi's language, the marks on paper are configured in perception into a spiral, and this perceptual spiral is focal in the subject's awareness. Both the interpreted data and the interpreting are subsidiary. The process by which the data are packaged into an interpreted form is what Polanyi would have called "tacit knowing":

This act of integration, which we can identify both in the visual perception of objects and in the discovery of scientific theories is the tacit power we have been looking for. I shall call it *tacit knowing*. It will facilitate my discussion of tacit knowing if I speak of the clues or parts that are subsidiarily known as the *proximal term* of tacit knowing and of that which is focally known as the *distal term* of tacit knowing. In the case of percep-

tion we are attending to an object separated from most of the clues which we integrate into its appearance; the proximal and the distal terms are then largely different objects, joined together by tacit knowing. This is not so when we know a whole by integrating its parts into their joint appearance, or when the discovery of a theory integrates observations into their theoretical appearance. In this case the proximal term consists of things seen in isolation, and the distal term consists of the same things seen as a coherent entity.¹²

In the case of the Fraser Spiral, the marks on paper are proximal and subsidiary in Polanyi's language, and the apparent spiral is focal. It is characteristic of the difference between the perspectives of Lonergan and Polanyi that Polanyi concentrates his attention on the distinction between focal and subsidiary, or distal and proximal, while Lonergan directs his attention toward discovering the operations by which one can move from the one to the other. It is also characteristic that Polanyi distinguishes between perception and scientific theorizing, but does not elaborate on the significance of the distinction. For Lonergan, on the other hand, the distinction is of crucial significance.

Lonergan has not been especially concerned with perception, but has concentrated on theoretical inquiry so as to distinguish it from what he calls "common sense" (of which the perceptual world would be a component). For this reason Lonergan's own discussion of cognitive operations refers to operations performed with conscious intention, but the example of the Fraser Spiral is useful nevertheless, because it shows how pervasive interpretative operations are and because it helps to make clear why rival epistemologies based on the assumption that knowing is a simple matter of taking a look could develop and maintain such a hold on the imagination. In most cases, the perceptions that grow out of unconscious processes of interpretation are sufficiently accurate for our purposes, and so we feel no need to probe more deeply how we know what we know. The classic pattern for the development of a skeptical attitude begins with an initial naive acceptance of the products of such automatic interpretation as though they were not interpretations but a direct vision of naked reality. Then when the budding skeptic notices that sense perception is not necessarily accurate

12. *Knowing and Being*, p. 140.

(as in the classic example of the stick that looks bent in the water), he is tempted to conclude that all supposed knowledge is illusory. The naive assumption is that if real knowledge were possible, it would come by way of a "look," and if "looks" are suspect, there can be no certitude. If one continues the inquiry further than such a collapse into skepticism, Lonergan would say, one can begin to discover the role of understanding and judgment in cognition. At that point one is in a position to find out what went wrong in the case of a misperception, like that of the stick in water or of the Fraser Spiral.

Since Lonergan was concerned primarily with the conscious operations by which knowledge in the proper sense is achieved (he would not consider Polanyi's "tacit knowing" to be knowledge in the proper sense, since it is not critically verified), it would be appropriate to consider briefly his conceptions of consciousness and of the subject who is conscious. The topic of consciousness is central to each of the philosophers this book deals with, but Lonergan, characteristically, is the only one to offer a technical definition of it. Probably his most succinct definition of what he means by "consciousness" appears in a Latin textbook written for his course in Christology at the Gregorian University (in which he discussed the consciousness of Jesus in a way that subsequently gave rise to some controversy among Catholic theologians): "Consciousness is an internal experience of one's self and one's acts, where experience is taken in the strict sense."¹³ "Experience," he says, "can be taken either in a broad sense or in a strict sense. Broadly speaking experience is practically the same as ordinary knowledge. Strictly speaking, it is a prior rudimentary knowledge which is presupposed and completed by intellectual inquiry." Experience in the strict sense, as Lonergan uses this term, is made up of mere data, which as taken up and subsumed by further inquiry may become the elements of an interpretation.

By "internal experience" Lonergan meant something very like what

13. *De Constitutione Christi Ontologica et Psychologica* (Rome: Gregorian University Press, 1956), part 5, section 1. I am quoting from the typescript of an English translation prepared by the Reverend Timothy P. Fallon, S. J., of the University of Santa Clara. For Lonergan's reply to a critic of his approach to the consciousness of Christ, see his "Christ as Subject: A Reply," in *Collection: Papers by Bernard Lonergan, S. J.*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe, S. J., pp. 164-97.

Polanyi did when he spoke of the “body” as that from which we attend in subsidiary awareness toward some focal object. For Lonergan, the distinction between “internal” and “external” and that between subject and object are essentially equivalent. As Lonergan explained it: “What we experience externally is apprehended as an object and by an act peculiarly its own. We see colors as objects, hear sounds as objects, taste flavors as objects. . . . But what we experience internally does not enter the field of knowledge in an act peculiarly its own nor is it apprehended as an object. In the very act of seeing color I find two elements entering the field of knowledge: color on the objective side, and both the one seeing and the act of seeing on the subjective side” (ibid.).

Polanyi would say that the experience of the act of seeing is subsidiary to what is seen (i.e., to what is focal); Lonergan would essentially agree, but he would also say that in this case the subsidiary is the experiential in the strict sense, and that this is precisely what consciousness is. One experiences on the subsidiary level one’s operations, but one can also shift one’s focus of inquiry toward the operating subject and come to “know” oneself as well as simply experience oneself operating: “Now this awareness of the one seeing and his act of seeing, of the one understanding and his act of understanding, of the one judging and his act of judging, is presupposed and fulfilled, first when one inquires what the one who sees, the one who understands, the one who judges is, and what seeing, understanding, and judging are, and second, when one judges about the ideas formed in answer to this inquiry. Therefore this awareness too is prior and rudimentary. It is, also, what we call experience in the strict sense” (ibid.).

To make fully clear what Lonergan means here, it is necessary to emphasize that when he is speaking of inquiry leading to knowledge of the subject, he is not speaking of a quasi perception or a special introspective mode of consciousness. On the contrary, he says that “consciousness is one thing and introspection quite another. . . . Consciousness is prior and rudimentary knowledge of oneself and one’s acts; introspection is consequent intellectual inquiry in which you grasp the intelligibility, quiddity, truth, and being of what you grasped by consciousness as experienced” (ibid.).¹⁴ The only introspection possible to a human

14. Cf. *Method*, pp. 8–9.

knower, in other words, is rational inquiry; the idea of being able to know oneself as subject by "taking a look" is just as much a will-o'-the-wisp as any other such perceptionist aspiration.

Consciousness, for Lonergan, is the experience of a subject, not the perception of an object; nor can consciousness be said to know anything at all as an object (*De Constitutione Christi*, 5, 3). Consciousness has no objects; it is the subject who by his operations intends objects. It is not consciousness, that is, but the conscious subject who through his attending, interpreting, and verifying comes not only to sense but also to understand and know the objects of experience, understanding, and knowledge. These operations are the conscious acts that constitute the subject, for as Lonergan puts it, "Subject or 'I,' as conscious, is this man existing and psychologically operating in his capacity as a subject experiencing his coming to know. . . . No-one is conscious unless he is operating psychologically" (*ibid.*, 5, 2). As he stated it in his 1968 lecture "The Subject": "The study of the subject . . . is the study of oneself inasmuch as one is conscious. It prescind from the soul, its essence, its potencies, its habits, for none of these is given in consciousness. It attends to operations and their centre and source which is the self. It discerns the different levels of consciousness, the consciousness of the dream, of the waking subject, of the intelligently inquiring subject, of the rationally reflecting subject, of the responsibly deliberating subject. It examines the operations on the several levels and their relations to one another."¹⁵

To be a subject, as Lonergan uses the term, is to be a performer of intentional operations, and one actually exists as subject to the exact degree that he consciously performs those operations. When he only experiences, he remains in simple immediacy and exists only as an experiencing or empirical subject, not an intellectual or rational subject. When, however, a person not only attends to immediate experience but also pursues meaning and through that pursuit arrives at insight into intelligible form, comprehending the empirical fragments as the elements of a coherent, structured whole, he exists as an understanding as well as experiencing subject. When he reflects critically on the adequacy of his understanding to the experiential data that it construes, he operates as a rational as well as an empirical and intellectual subject. If an individual

15. Lonergan, *Second Collection*, ed. William F. Ryan, S. J., and Bernard J. Tyrell, p. 73.

neglects to notice that it is precisely and only in his operations that he exists as an actual subject, then he may fail to perform those operations and miss the opportunity to exist as one. As Lonergan put it in "The Subject": "The neglected subject does not know himself. The truncated subject not only does not know himself but also is unaware of his ignorance and so, in one way or another, concludes that what he does not know does not exist" (p. 73). Contrasting with the neglected and truncated subject, on the other hand, there is the existential subject, the one who knows what it is to act and consciously does so: "Such doing, at first sight, affects, modifies, changes the world of objects. But even more it affects the subject himself. For human doing is free and responsible. Within it is contained the reality of morals, of building up or destroying character, of achieving personality or failing in that task. By his own acts the human subject makes himself what he is to be . . ." (p. 79).

The subject as conceived by Lonergan is, then, the conscious performer of intentional operations. This means that the subject must be considered under three aspects: as conscious, as operating, and as capable of operating.

Consciousness, as was said, Lonergan defines as simply experience. It is a central feature of the operating subject, but it is not itself a distinct operation; rather it is the immediate self-presence of the subject in operations. Consciousness, he says, "is not another operation over and above the operation that is experienced. It is that very operation which, besides being intrinsically intentional [i.e., oriented toward objects], also is intrinsically conscious" (*Method*, p. 8). Or as he put it in *Insight*, "by consciousness we shall mean that there is an awareness immanent in cognitional acts. . . . To affirm consciousness is to affirm that cognitional process is not merely a procession of contents but also a succession of acts" (p. 320).

The conscious operations of the subject are dynamic intentions. Specifically they intend the noticing of data of sense and consciousness, the understanding of what is potentially intelligible, the verifying of understanding as truth, and ultimately the deciding for the good, which is to say, the truly desirable. "The operations," says Lonergan, "then, stand within a process that is formally dynamic, that calls forth and assembles its own components, that does so intelligently, rationally, responsibly," and it is the unifying force of this dynamism that explains "the unity and relatedness of the several operations" (*Method*, p. 16).

The active capacity for such unified, conscious, dynamic intentions Lonergan called a “transcendental notion.” Unfortunately Lonergan, who usually gave definitions for his key terms, not only did not define what exactly he meant by a “notion” but used the term in different ways in different connections. Frequently he used it in the ordinary way of common speech to refer to a rough idea of something (I will call this meaning “sense A”). Sometimes, however, he used it in a less common way (which I will call “sense B”) with an emphasis on subjective activity, as when he refers in *Method* to transcendental notions as “the active potencies . . . revealed in questions for intelligence, questions for reflection, questions for deliberation” (p. 120). When he goes on immediately afterward (p. 121) to speak of this conception of subjective operation as displacing such outmoded ideas as “the notion of pure intellect or pure reason” and “the notion of will,” on the other hand, he is using the term in sense A. Perhaps the best way to elucidate Lonergan’s “notion” (in sense A) of a transcendental “notion” (sense B) would be to say that by the latter term he meant not an idea or concept, even in a rudimentary sense, but rather a dynamic anticipation of the goal of intention. Interpreted in this way, the transcendental notion of the intelligible, for example, is one’s active anticipation of a possible understanding. One has some experience that is not yet understood but which seems to contain some latent possibility of meaningfulness; then one strives by efforts of construing to reach from that “buzzing, blooming, confusion,” as William James called it, toward a pattern that will satisfactorily subsume and order the data. The notion is transcendental in the sense that it is an anticipation of the intelligible as such, rather than of any particular pattern, which would be, in Lonergan’s terminology, “categorical” rather than “transcendental.” (By “transcendental” Lonergan simply meant that which cuts across the boundaries of particular categories; he did not mean anything like “otherworldly” or “mystical.”) What Lonergan seems to have meant is that what the transcendental notion of the intelligible intends is not so much the particular intelligible object, but the satisfying act of understanding that the subject will be capable of performing when the process of interpretation is completed.

There are several transcendental notions in Lonergan’s schematism—one for each type of operation. The transcendental notion of truth is the dynamic anticipation of verified knowledge, that of the good is the anticipation of satisfaction as such. (Thus Lonergan can

speak of truth as the good of intellect.) The transcendental notions, in other words, are the dynamic anticipations of the fulfillment of the human longing to experience, to understand, to know, and to take appropriate action within the context of reality. "The transcendental notions," says Lonergan, are the dynamism of conscious intentionality. They promote the subject from lower to higher levels of consciousness, from the experiential to the intellectual, from the intellectual to the rational, from the rational to the existential" (*Method*, pp. 34–5). And not only do they "promote the subject to full consciousness and direct him to his goals" in this way, says Lonergan, but "they also provide the criteria that reveal whether the goals are being reached. The drive to understand is satisfied when understanding is reached but it is dissatisfied with every incomplete attainment" and so impels one to further questions (p. 35). Similarly the drives to truth and value come to rest only when the conditions for a reasonable assent or wise choice are fulfilled. In this way the transcendental notions move the subject in a process that is his coming to be as an actual rather than merely potential subject on the successive levels of conscious operation.

The levels of consciousness, like the operations that constitute them, are interrelated and cumulative, and so are the dynamic notions that give rise to them. Understanding builds upon the experience it understands; critical reflection reflects upon the understanding it seeks to verify; and the question of what to do pursues appropriateness of action in the real situation that is experienced, understood, and known. It is in this dynamic integration of the operations on the several levels that Lonergan's parallel to Hegel's *Aufhebung* or "sublation" is to be found. In Lonergan's words, "we describe interiority in terms of intentional and conscious acts on the four levels of experiencing, understanding, judging, and deciding. The lower levels are presupposed and complemented by the higher. The higher sublimate the lower" (*Method*, p. 120). Understanding sublimes experience in that without experiential data there would be nothing to understand; and the experience does not disappear when it is understood, but becomes experience understood. So also understanding does not disappear when it is judged correct; rather there is a single consciousness made up of distinct but mutually involved acts intending an object that is experience understood and verified. To phrase the issue in Polanyi's language, the lower levels of operation and their objects become subsidiary for the higher levels as the

objects of the higher levels become focal. Reality or truth is focal for judgment, but that is intended *by way of* the subsidiary particulars of experience and understanding.

As these levels of intentionality successively sublate one another, the unity into which they are integrated is an achieved unity; it is the result of consciously performing the operations. When we considered the example of our perception of the Fraser Spiral, that was not an instance of such an achieved unity of operations, because the only conscious operations involved were those on the empirical level: the attending to marks on paper and to the spiral pattern that was the result of an unconscious process of packaging that took place in the central nervous system. The higher levels of operation can have unconscious analogues, but they are the operations of an actual subject for Lonergan only when they are consciously performed.

Besides the achieved unity of consciousness that is the fruit of successive, sublating operations, there can also be an apparent unity like that of the perceiver of the Fraser Spiral. In such a case there are several distinct operations, but not all of them are conscious, and therefore they are not all genuinely subjective operations, but only processes that impinge upon the subject insofar as the subject notices their results. The resulting consciousness, however, despite the subject's impressions, is neither intellectual nor rational, but only empirical. Or else, in a case where there is not only experience but some conscious interpreting that is nevertheless uncriticized, there may be intellectual as well as empirical consciousness, but not rational.

The development of the capacity to perform the different operations distinctly and purposefully Lonergan calls "differentiation of consciousness." Ordinarily an individual begins with a mentality that easily leaps to conclusions, blurring the operations or letting certain ones lapse altogether, noticing only what is obvious or apparently advantageous, mistaking fantasy or dream for reality, and so on. It is usually only difficulty and disappointment that lead to reflective self-awareness and the development of a capacity for distinguishing the various cognitive operations and performing each with care. Even a person capable of performing them distinctly when he wishes will frequently respond as though they were not distinct at all, but a single power through which the true or the good is immediately grasped. Polanyi's "tacit knowing" as described above was precisely this sort of undifferentiated response;

in it, to phrase the issue in Lonerganian terms, the operations are experienced but not distinctly; they are performed, but not adverted to.

In one of his works on the history of theology Lonergan gave a brief account of the differentiation of consciousness in the following terms: "Consciousness is undifferentiated where the whole person is involved, operating simultaneously and equally with all of his powers. Differentiated consciousness, on the other hand, is capable of operating exclusively, or at least principally, on a single level, while the other levels are either entirely subordinated to the attainment of the goal of that level, or at least are held in check, so that they do not hinder its attainment. . . . the scientist, or the speculative thinker, tends towards a goal that is not that of the whole man, but only of his intellect. The will is therefore restricted to willing the good of intellect, which is the truth; imagination throws up only those images that induce understanding or suggest a judgment; feelings and emotions, finally, are as if anaesthetised, so firmly are they kept in control."¹⁶

Corresponding to the distinction between undifferentiated and differentiated consciousness is a parallel distinction between realms of meaning. To undifferentiated consciousness corresponds what Lonergan calls the world of "common sense." This is made up of our ordinary experience and our comparatively unreflective, though not necessarily inadequate, interpretations and judgments. It tends to be a world of widely shared assumptions and intuitions which most individuals believe to be true because they feel natural and seem obvious to them—as if they knew them by "taking a look" at objective facts—and because so many other people believe them unquestioningly. To differentiated consciousness, on the other hand, correspond two distinct cognitive realms, depending on whether the focus is the objective or the subjective pole of consciousness: the realm of theory and that of what Lonergan calls "interiority."¹⁷

When one realizes that what one knows objectively is what one can know only to the extent that one has noticed experiential data, interpreted them, and critically verified the interpretation, then, if one

16. *The Way to Nicea: The Dialectical Development of Trinitarian Theology*, translated by Conn O'Donovan from the first part of *De Deo Trino*, pp. 2–3.

17. See *Method*, pp. 81–85. Lonergan also refers briefly in these pages to a fourth realm of meaning, that of "transcendence," which will be discussed further in the later part of this chapter.

wishes to communicate, one is eventually led to realize also that it is necessary to develop a precise language with which to describe the objects of such theoretical inquiry. The world of common sense we can describe in ordinary language, and everyone we speak to will know approximately what we are talking about, because the conceptions as well as the language are shared, even if imprecisely. The commonsense realm of discourse—in which all of us participate in our ordinary living and conversation—is not one in which precise meanings are in great demand. The shift to theory, on the other hand, brings with it a need for precision, since only what is precisely formulated can be critically tested, and theoretical inquiry cannot be satisfied with vague hypotheses or unverified assertions.

Historically the realm of theory opened up earlier than the realm of interiority, says Lonergan, because thinkers became aware of the need for precise description of the objective before they became aware of the ground of objectivity in subjective operations carefully performed. In other words, the transition from common sense to theory has taken place gradually, and there has been an interim period of transition—not yet completed for many thinkers—during which it has been widely assumed that theoretical objectivity is to be achieved by a passive receptivity in the subject (the epistemology of the naked look) rather than by an active, internally differentiated process of careful interpretation.

The opening of the realm of interiority, however, has also been a process in human history, and Lonergan insists that in the final analysis it is inexorable, because the epistemology of the look does not hold up in practice but leads, when it breaks down, to questions about the ground of knowledge. These impel the discovery of interiority, which, as Lonergan uses the term, refers to our cognitive operations considered in their aspect as consciously performed by a subject moved by the dynamism of the transcendental notions. The discovery of interiority is, in fact, precisely what was referred to above as the introspective objectification of consciousness through inquiry into its operations. As Lonergan put the matter in *Method in Theology*, “the transition from common sense and theory to interiority promotes us from consciousness of self to knowledge of self” (p. 259). In doing so it provides the critical ground for the realm of theory, since clarity regarding interiority makes clear what our habitual commonsense perspective can so easily obscure: that

the only reality we can ever actually know is that which we are able to understand and verify.

In the language of common sense, “reality” is made up of “external objects” that we can perceive through our senses. In the world of theory, on the other hand, reality is not what is sensed but what is critically known, and what is known in that way is not directly the object of experience, but of understanding and reflective judgment. The world of theory, as Lonergan states it, is a world mediated by meaning, and its objects are of a quite different character from those intended in the world of common sense:

There are, then, two quite disparate meanings of the term, object. There is the object in the world mediated by meaning: it is what is intended by the question, and it is what becomes understood, affirmed, decided by the answer. To this type of object we are related immediately by our questions and only mediately by the operations relevant to answers, for the answers refer to objects only because they are answers to questions.

But there is another quite different meaning of the term, object. For besides the world mediated by meaning there also is a world of immediacy. It is a world quite apart from questions and answers, a world in which we lived before we spoke and while we were learning to speak, a world into which we try to withdraw when we would forget the world mediated by meaning, when we relax, play, rest. In that world the object is neither named nor described. But in the world mediated by meaning one can recollect and reconstitute the object of the world of immediacy. It is already, out, there, now, real. It is *already*: it is given prior to any questions about it. It is *out*: for it is the object of extroverted consciousness. It is *there*: as sense organs, so too sensed objects are spatial. It is *now*: for the time of sensing runs along with the time of what is sensed. It is *real*: for it is bound up with one’s living and acting and so must be just as real as they are.” (*Method in Theology*, pp. 262–63)

It was over the distinction between these two worlds—the world of theory with its critically affirmed conceptions and the world of common sense with its felt conviction regarding the “already, out, there, now, real” object—that we saw a representative of the analytic school of philosophy clash with Polanyi in the last chapter. In Lonergan’s terms, the encounter between Olding and Polanyi could be described as

one between a commonsense perspective on the one hand and an incompletely developed theoretical one on the other. Analytical philosophy tends, as its emphasis on "ordinary language" might suggest, to begin from commonsense assumptions about reality and then to ask theoretical questions about the implications of those assumptions. Its contributions to deflating the claims of inadequate theory have been considerable, but it has always had some difficulty itself with the transition from common sense to adequate theory. The problem Olding pointed out in Polanyi's discussion of the part-whole relation in composite things, however, is a real one and worth considering for the light it can throw on the difference between Polanyi and Lonergan as well as on the question of the nature of theoretical reality.

Polanyi's discussion of the "tacit dimension" and the relation between subsidiary and focal awareness was a probe into the field of what Lonergan calls interiority, but as his use of the term "tacit" indicates, Polanyi left much of that territory implicit. In particular, although he had a sound appreciation of the roles of the distinct cognitive operations Lonergan discusses, he did not emphasize their distinctness, and in his discussion of the tacit dimension he seemed to assume that it was not especially important to advert to them distinctly.¹⁸ One result was that Polanyi did not develop the clear distinction Lonergan did between differentiated and undifferentiated consciousness.

Another result was that when Polanyi came to explain the correlation between the subjective and objective poles of knowing, the only way he had developed to understand this was in terms of the relation between focal and subsidiary awareness. So when Polanyi discussed the relation between part and whole in an objectively real entity, he spoke of the parts as subsidiary and the whole as focal, since in knowing the thing as a whole we can be said to notice its elements but focus on their synthesis within a unity. Lonergan would agree that in consciousness lower levels are sublated by higher and are in that respect subsidiary to them, but he

18. Even so, the entire schema of intentional operations that Lonergan emphasized was articulated also by Polanyi in closely similar terms. See, for example, pp. 28–39 of *The Study of Man* where he describes "the act of understanding" as "a process of *comprehending*: a grasping of disjointed parts into a comprehensive whole" (p. 28) then goes on to speak of an "intellectual passion which impels us towards making ever closer contact with reality" (p. 34) and thereby seeks "satisfaction" or "intellectual joy" (p. 37) in the judgment of "fact" and also grounds the "appreciation of values."

would not consider that, by itself, a sufficient account of the relation between elements and the wholes they constitute as objective realities. It is possible, from Lonergan's point of view, to distinguish sensory data from structured form, and therefore it can make sense to speak of them as related in a manner parallel to that between subsidiary and focal awareness when the form is actually understood and is consequently the focus of intention. But it is also possible to discuss the discovery of coherent form (the "whole") through efforts to render explicit the possibilities of pattern latent in a set of experiential data by construing them as related in some manner. The first way of speaking is actually metaphorical, since from the point of view of intentionality analysis, understanding (the operation in which a grasp of structure takes place) is distinct from attention considered in itself. When Polanyi spoke, as we saw, of a machine's parts as being "harnessed" by its design, Olding was justified in pointing out that this was at most a suggestive metaphor and not a theoretical explanation. Similarly he was justified in pointing out the uncritically vitalistic connotations this kind of language introduced into Polanyi's discussion of the emergence of forms out of the randomness of particulars. With little more than the focal-subsidiary relation to work with, Polanyi did not have a very refined set of conceptual instruments for the analysis of such phenomena. The problem with the language of focal and subsidiary awareness, Lonergan would probably say, is that it connotes an ocular analogy that implies that knowing is a kind of "look"—which from Lonergan's point of view, of course, would be a fundamental misconception in cognitional theory.

Lonergan's own discussion of these issues is more detailed, precise, and rigorous. Let us consider the examples of his treatment of the concepts of the part-whole relation in a unified "thing" and of "emergence" (emergence, that is, of increasingly complex syntheses or patterns of interrelatedness), both of which were mentioned at the end of the last chapter as having remained somewhat ambiguous in the thought of Polanyi.

As we saw, there are, according to Lonergan, two distinct types of knowing: the experientially immediate and that which involves mediating processes of inquiry, interpretation, critical reflection, and verification. The first type Lonergan terms "elementary"; the second he refers to as "fully human knowing," since it calls into play the full range of possible human cognitive operations whereas elementary knowing we

share with other animals. It is in this elementary sense, we saw him say, that "kittens know the 'reality' of milk" (*Insight*, p. 252). Both types of knowing have their validity, and their respective objects are genuine, though different.

Problems arise when the types of knowing are confused. As Lonergan put it: "The perennial source of nonsense is that, after the scientist has verified his hypothesis, he is likely to go a little further and tell the layman what, approximately, scientific reality looks like! Already, we have attacked the unverifiable image; but now we can see the origin of the strange urge to foist upon mankind unverifiable images. For both the scientist and the layman, besides being intelligent and reasonable, also are animals. To them as animals, a verified hypothesis is just a jumble of words or symbols. What they want is an elementary knowing of the 'really real,' if not through sense, at least by imagination" (p. 253). What all of us wish, in other words, at least at times, is to be able to know a world of "already, out, there, now, real" things not by critical judgment but by a look.

Confusing the types of knowing in this way results in confusing their objects. The objects of experientially immediate or elementary knowing are apprehended by sense and imagination as wholes, but their unity is not critically comprehended. To distinguish these from the objects of theoretical inquiry, Lonergan makes a distinction between "body" and "thing" (p. 253). By a "thing" in this technical sense he means "an intelligible concrete unity." Among "things" he further distinguishes the idea of "a thing for us, a thing as described," on the one hand, and "a thing itself, a thing as explained" on the other. Description pertains to the thing for us, the thing as it relates to our powers of observation; explanation pertains to the relations of the elements of the thing to one another. By a "body" Lonergan means "a focal point of extroverted biological anticipation and attention" (p. 254). The milk is a "body" in this sense to the kitten, but so also are most of the objects that fill our commonsense world, since in the context of that world what we know is mostly packaged into chunks of data that are taken to be "already, out, there, now, real."

In his discussion of metaphysics, Lonergan analyzes the thing itself, the real object in the world of theory, in terms of relations in the thing that correlate with relations in knowing. The simplest explanation why our knowing has its particular structure, he says, is that "proportionate

being has a parallel structure" to our knowing (p. 499). By "proportionate being" he means reality insofar as it is suited to knowing by the means available to human inquiry. Proportionate being, he says, is intrinsically intelligible because it is precisely that which we are able to inquire into. Traditional Aristotelian metaphysics distinguished within the structure of "things" between potency, form, and act. Lonergan considered these terms still useful, but he also recognized that his analysis and Aristotle's have very different points of departure, in that Aristotle was oriented primarily toward descriptive knowledge and still had one foot in the world of sensory extroversion and common sense, while Lonergan aimed at explanatory knowledge and accepted fully the implications of the shift to theory (p. 433). Aristotle could speak of matter or potency, form, and act as though they were simply objective. Lonergan correlated them directly with the proportionate operations by which they are known. Correlative to Aristotle's potency or matter, from Lonergan's point of view, are the data of experience. Correlative to intelligible structure or form is insight. Correlative to act, the existence of the real thing, is the judgment by which it is known as actual. The correlations, moreover, are perfect, because from Lonergan's point of view there is no way one can ever know about a real thing in the world of theory except by experience, understanding, and judgment. What is not yet understood and judged actual is not known as a real thing at all; it is apprehended merely as a manifold of experiential data.

To state simply the issue Lonergan was concerned with, cognition necessarily involves two poles, the subjective and the objective, and these correlate with one another. There is no object that is not known or is not at least knowable through some subjective operations; nor is there a cognitive subject that does not intend some object through some operations.

Of course this must sound odd to common sense, but that, Lonergan would have said, is simply because common sense is not theory and knows nothing of theoretical objects. To a thinker who cannot or will not proceed past common sense to theory and its grounding in interiority, Lonergan would probably sound like an idealist because it would sound as if he were talking about the objects of the world of common sense and denying that they have external reality. In fact, however, Lonergan was not talking about the same sort of object at all, but about the objects of theoretical inquiry. The difference is really not one be-

tween two different ways of looking at a single object, but between differentiated and undifferentiated consciousness. The subject of differentiated consciousness can engage, with a clear awareness of its distinctive procedures, in theoretical inquiry, but he can also engage in "looking" (i.e., in perceiving). What is important is that differentiated consciousness knows the difference between them and does not confuse these two ways of "knowing" or their objects. Undifferentiated consciousness, on the other hand, is aware of only one procedure and one world, even if it sometimes finds itself drawn to ask questions that probe into the realm of theory. Undifferentiated consciousness, that is, always thinks it is "looking" at things "out there," even when it may actually be doing something quite different.

The distinctions between these different ways of knowing and their correlative objects make it possible to carry further the analysis that was suggested only briefly and incompletely in the last chapter with regard to the clash between Polanyi and his empiricist opponent regarding the emergence of wholes by way of the synthesis of their elements. Olding, as we saw there, espoused a mechanistic view of the combination of particulars in nature, and in this respect he was like philosophers of the analytic school generally, who tend to conceive of reality as made up of the external objects of common sense, "bits of the universe," as he phrased it, "interacting with other bits."¹⁹ It is to be expected, Lonergan would say, that such a pattern of thought would clash with that which seeks to understand the emergence of higher forms from the synthesis of lower. "Mechanistic determinism," he says, "is bound to conceive all things as of a single kind. For mechanism posits things as instances of the 'already out there now real.' Determinism makes every event completely determined by laws of the classical type. And the combination of the two views leaves no room for a succession of ever higher systems; for mechanism would require the higher component to be a 'body,' and determinism would exclude the possibility of the higher component modifying lower activities" (*Insight*, p. 255).

The notion of the theoretical entity as that which is explained by the relations among elements in a system, on the other hand, points in the direction of a world of different kinds of things explainable in different ways through the different sorts of relations among their elements.

19. Olding, "Polanyi's Notion," p. 102.

From this point of view, one can explain the workings of a machine by the interaction of elements that by themselves could be construed as “bodies” in the commonsense meaning (hence the appeal of mechanistic conceptions to common sense), but one can also explain nonmechanical systems in terms of different types of elements and relations. Lonergan’s account of theoretical knowing, as described above, would be an example of precisely this sort of explanation. The elements of theoretical knowing are experiential data, three types of cognitive operation and the transcendental notions that impel, guide, and measure them, and they are related as mutually dependent and cumulative. The source of these operations is the fundamental dynamism of consciousness itself, of which the transcendental notions and the particular operations they motivate are immediate expressions. When these operations are successfully carried out in relation to one another and the data they work with, they result in an integrated unity of consciousness that is attentive, intelligent, and reasonable, and this in turn can become the cognitive foundation for wise decisions about courses of action. When they are not successfully carried out—when attention is only partial, understanding is unclear, or judgment is insufficiently critical—then they result in fragmented consciousness and an incoherent life, the life of what Lonergan referred to as the “truncated subject” (*Second Collection*, p. 73).

By analyzing human consciousness in such terms, as a nonmechanistic system, one is able to explain success and failure in the project of human existence without reducing humanity to a form of mechanism and thereby eclipsing what calls for explanation. And one is able to explain the specifically human in this way without any implication that this should entail interpreting lower organisms or machines vitalistically, as though their operations were intentional (in the case of machines) or (in the case of lower organisms) involved higher levels of intentionality than they are capable of.

The difference between different types of explanation, as Lonergan interprets it, is the difference between lower and higher viewpoints. Lower viewpoints are adequate to the explanation of the patterns that emerge on a lower level of organization within a system. The laws of subatomic elements explain the patterns of organization among such entities. They cannot, however, explain the patterns found on the level of molecular chemistry, biology, or human culture. The same is true of

mechanistic explanation; it can explain machines as mechanisms, but it cannot address the further questions that could arise regarding the possible purposes machines could serve, their influence on society and culture, and so on. In this respect, "the lower viewpoint," says Lonergan, "is insufficient for it has to regard as merely coincidental what in fact is regular" (*Insight*, p. 256).

Higher levels of organization require their own sciences to explain them, just as the lower levels require theirs, and to confuse them is simply to fail to consider carefully what is at issue. The introduction of the higher autonomous science does not, says Lonergan, "interfere with the autonomy of the lower; for the higher enters into the field of the lower only insofar as it makes systematic on the lower level what otherwise would be merely coincidental" (p. 256). The laws of psychic stimulus and response, for example, elucidate the systematic features of what otherwise, on the level of the nervous system alone, would be "merely coincidental aggregates of neural events" and by themselves would seem meaningless without reference to the psychic system they serve (p. 263).

The emergence of higher levels of organization in the object, from this point of view, correlates directly with the discovery of intelligible pattern and does so because what Lonergan calls proportionate being is by its very nature correlative to the operations by which it can be known. The reason we find hierarchy in reality is that the reality we can know is proportionate to our knowing. As understanding presupposes attention to experiential data, and verified knowledge presupposes some act of understanding that needs testing, so we also discover in reality itself structural patterns that constitute the objective pole of a variety of interrelated lines of inquiry. As Lonergan explains, "The prototype of emergence is the insight that arises with respect to an appropriate image; without the insight, the image is a coincidental manifold; by the insight the elements of the image become intelligibly united and related; moreover, accumulations of insights unify and relate ever greater and more diversified ranges of images, and what remains merely coincidental from a lower viewpoint becomes systematic from the accumulations of insights in a higher viewpoint" (p. 483).

It is in accordance with this principle that Lonergan is able to explain "a basic fact which a mechanistic viewpoint has tended to overlook and

to obscure, namely, that immanent intelligibility or constitutive design increases in significance as one mounts from higher to still higher systems" (p. 264). Higher viewpoints are initiated by further questions. For example, the merely empirical is considered from a higher viewpoint when the question of relations between elemental data is raised; the merely intelligible is considered from a higher viewpoint when the question of adequacy to evidence is raised. Similarly, an organism or a machine is considered from a higher viewpoint when it is considered in the light of the questions raised by a biologist or engineer rather than those of, say, a chemist.

Polanyi understood this implicitly, but his failure to work out its foundation in cognitional theory left his position seemingly vulnerable to an attack from the standpoint of quasi-theoretical commonsense, and it is natural that from such a point of view Polanyi's leap across a gap of tacit knowing would seem a kind of fideistic obscurantism. Lonergan's more explicit discussion, on the other hand, makes clear that if anyone should claim that there is or could be a reality of any other kind than that which is proportionate to human insights and powers of verification, it is actually that person who demands of us an unreasoned assent to what is unintelligible and unverifiable in principle.

The clarity Lonergan is able by his method of analysis to bring to bear on the questions of what we know as reality and how we know it is impressive. Its value for any investigator will depend, of course, on his willingness to accept and live consistently within the constraints of Lonergan's distinction between the realms of common sense, theory, and interiority, and that will probably depend largely upon the need he feels for inquiry that reaches beyond common sense. The fact is that for most of us most of the time, the commonsense world is the only one that interests us, and we rarely feel a need to ask questions that reach beyond its limits. Almost any field of investigation, however, if inquired into deeply enough, eventually leads into the realm of theory with its more precise use of language and its more clearly delimited conception of what can and cannot be known in the strict sense of the word.

Even professional theorists sometimes find this disconcerting. Heinz Pagels writes that "Enrico Fermi, the Italian-American physicist, as he witnessed the proliferation of hadrons, commented that had he known this was to become the outcome of nuclear physics, he would have stud-

ied zoology.”²⁰ Pagels also tells how after discovering relativity with equanimity, Einstein balked at the disturbing implications of quantum theory. Midway through his book, Pagels presents an imaginary philosophical dialogue between various contemporary schools of physicists over what the term “reality” can mean in a context in which what can be theoretically understood and experimentally verified runs so directly counter to all of our commonsense ideas about bodies in space. The dialogue concludes with some comments from Niels Bohr, who says that unlike most of the others in this imaginary “Reality Marketplace,” he has come to terms with quantum reality: “There is no quantum world,” he says, “like the ordinary world of familiar objects like tables and chairs, and we should stop looking for it. . . . Previous to the invention of the quantum theory, physicists could think of the world in terms of its objects independent of *how* they knew that world existed. Quantum reality also has things—the quanta-like electrons and photons—but given along with that world is a structure of information which is ultimately reflected in how we speak about quantum reality. Quantum measurement theory is an information theory. The quantum world has disappeared into what we can know about it, and what we can know about it must come from actual experimental arrangements—there is no other way” (p. 187). The quantum world, he says, is not visualizable, and to know and describe it adequately, one must refrain from projecting fantasies into it.

Pagels’s imagined Bohr calls this “a minimalist approach to reality” (p. 188). It is in effect the same as Lonergan’s, who could also be termed a “minimalist” of this sort; the real, in the only sense in which that term can be used with theoretical precision, is what we can know by critical reflection and judgment when the fulfilling conditions for judgment include experiential data—data of sense or data of consciousness.

Where, however, does that leave the inquirer himself? What he knows in this way can be termed real, but can he himself be spoken of as real in the same sense? For Lonergan he can, because, as was discussed earlier, he can consider himself as an object of inquiry, and in so doing can discover that “cognitive process is not merely a procession of contents but also a succession of acts” that are characterized by the immanent awareness called “consciousness” (*Insight*, pp. 320–21).

20. *The Cosmic Code*, p. 219.

Discovering these conscious acts within himself, the inquirer who knows what rational affirmation is can go on to his own rational self-affirmation as a knower—as one, that is, who consciously performs cognitive operations founded on the data of his experience.

Still, this may leave us feeling that Lonergan has framed the question in a way that overly restricts its scope and perhaps unconsciously presupposes an answer conforming to that favored by the scholastic metaphysics Lonergan was trained in. He has asked what, considered as a theoretical object, a person or subject could be judged to be; and he has answered that it is a certain type of entity, the type that we call a “subject.” To say that we are such entities, however, ultimately suggests more questions, and perhaps thornier ones, than it answers. For one thing, it interprets the subject as a type of object, and it has seemed to many thinkers in traditions other than Lonergan’s that an adequate understanding of subjectivity depends on a clear recognition of the absolute difference between subject and object. One can hardly help but feel, moreover, that the objective question of “what” a person is does not fully exhaust the potential significance of questions more oriented toward subjectivity. Such questions begin not with “what” but with “who” or “why” and explore what it means to exist subjectively—to exist, that is, as consciously and purposively operating, not as some type of theoretically defined, rationally affirmed metaphysical entity but as an indefinable, inherently perplexing, metaphysically questionable process. In the next chapter we will find Eric Voegelin drawing on the language of ancient myth and of classical philosophy to recover symbols for a much more subtly differentiated notion of the subjective dimension of human existence, and we will also find him objecting strongly to any tendency to reduce this to objectivity by reification, or what he called “hypostatizing.”

When we discover ourselves in the midst of the drama of our lives, the “who” or “why” questions can seem to have both greater urgency and greater scope than does the more objective and comparatively abstract question of “what” we are. There may also be more than just a residue of commonsense habits of thought in our feeling that even if at our most lucid and fully actualized we may be described as attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible subjects, there are some irreducibly “tacit,” nonobjectifiable processes at work in us that we must take into account in seeking to understand our humanity.

Loneragan himself, in fact, shifted his focus during the course of his career from a relatively greater emphasis on the objective in *Insight* to an emphasis in his later works on what is sometimes called the “existential” dimension of human being—the dimension in which the task of the subject is not to ground critically his belief that he exists, but to discover in the depths of his existence, as immediately experienced and intended, the dynamism that moves him not simply to inquire about objective reality but to seek spiritual as well as cognitive self-transcendence. Lonergan’s treatment of the subjective dimension and of what in his lecture “The Subject” he termed the “existential” level of consciousness, which expresses itself in the decision for subjective existence, remained, however, rather sketchy.²¹ The denseness and painstaking explicitness of his analysis of the objectively oriented operations of insight and judgment in the first six hundred pages or so of *Insight* represent a truly remarkable theoretical contribution. His treatment of the “subject” in that context, however, was necessarily cast in objectifying terms because the argument of that work was structured as requiring culmination in the rational self-affirmation of the subject as a theoretical object.

Also possible, but not actually explored by Lonergan, might have been the move, favored by the existential tradition of philosophy, entirely beyond the perspective in which whatever exists must be conceived of as some type of object. It may be, in other words, that our preliminary theoretical notion of a “subject” cannot in the last analysis be adequately conceived as proportionate being, but must be radically revised if we are to discover the actuality it points toward. Considered in such a way, the concept of an objective “subject” would have to be interpreted as an analogical symbol standing for what is ultimately irreducible to an object of any sort. Analogy, however, is not a theme that Lonergan has treated with anything like the thoroughness of his discussions of strictly objective cognition.

It seems indicative of the sketchiness of Lonergan’s treatment of existential subjectivity that in *Method in Theology*, after discussing at length the realms of meaning he distinguishes as “common sense,” “theory,” and “interiority,” he mentions only briefly that there is also a realm of what he calls “transcendence,” but scarcely defines it except to

21. *Second Collection*, pp. 79–86.

say that it is “the realm in which God is known and loved” (p. 84). Then when he returns to that topic in the chapter on religion, he defines “faith” not as a claim to objective “knowledge” in the sense in which he usually uses that term but as “the knowledge born of religious love” (p. 115). That this is not at all the sort of objective knowledge consisting of verified hypotheses that he usually refers to as knowledge “in the strict sense” is made clear by his statement that “besides the factual knowledge reached by experiencing, understanding, and verifying, there is another kind of knowledge reached through the discernment of value and the judgments of value of a person in love” (p. 115). This, however, is a fundamentally different kind of “knowing” from those Lonergan has elsewhere defined, and he never stops to explain how it happens that at this point he has to shift ground so radically and what the implications of that shift must be. It amounts, one might say, to a shift from what might be called “knowing from without” to “knowing from within,” and it would seem to imply that there is something irreducibly subjective in the “object” Lonergan is trying to analyze.²²

Lonergan’s discussions of value, freedom, and decision, in which he believes the subjective dimension of human existence manifests itself most fully, are also comparatively brief. In *Insight* he approached these questions primarily in terms of the distinction between objects of desire on the one hand and “the good of order” on the other (pp. 596–98). This became the basis for a treatment of value that placed true value in the world mediated by meaning: whatever one desires is good at least in an elementary sense, but rational valuation takes account of the place of the object of immediate desire in the real situation as understood and known. Responsible decision, then, pertains to that which is known to be desirable within the context of an ordered system. This is a teleological approach to ethics and for that reason alone would probably seem suspect to most contemporary philosophers of the analytic persuasion. But there is nothing inherently illogical about teleology as such, and Lonergan’s way of talking about it makes sense in relation to his general treatment of human operations and their objects. Still, it is hardly worked out with the care for detail Lonergan gave to the earlier levels of

22. For a discussion of the distinction between these two types of knowing in the context of a comparison between Lonergan and Voegelin, who places much greater emphasis on “knowing from within,” see Webb, *Eric Voegelin*, chapter 3, “Philosophical Knowing as an Existential Process,” pp. 89–128, especially pp. 92–95, 103–7.

operation, and in certain respects it leaves crucial concepts ambiguous.

This can be seen, for example, in a passage from *Method in Theology*: “The fourth level, which presupposes, complements, and sublates the other three, is the level of freedom and responsibility, of moral self-transcendence and in that sense of existence, of self-direction and self-control. Its failure to function properly is the uneasy or the bad conscience. Its success is marked by the satisfying feeling that one’s duty has been done” (p. 121). There are in this passage several ambiguous or incompletely analyzed concepts that Lonergan does not address at any length either here or elsewhere in his works. “Duty,” for example, is not a term he uses often or defines; in fact, it does not appear in the index of either *Insight* or *Method in Theology*. The term has been used in a variety of ways historically: as an obligation defined by a system of positive law or by divine decree, for example, or as one grounded in natural law, or, in a Kantian framework, as a transcendental imperative grounded in the a priori principles of rationality as such. Lonergan’s use of “duty” in the passage quoted seems to be a commonsense use of the term, and would require a more theoretical development to integrate it into a systematic analysis of the sort he gave to the first three levels of intentional operation.

Similarly in need of further analysis are the concepts of “self-transcendence” and “existence.” If the difference between the apparent good and true value is, as Lonergan’s treatment in *Insight* implied, the difference between objects of unreflective desire and objects of well-informed desire, in what sense is the term “self” used in the phrase “self-transcendence”? If “self” is taken to mean “subject” in the sense of the metaphysical entity affirmed in *Insight*, could not what Lonergan here calls self-transcendence just as appropriately be termed self-discovery, since what is in question is the discovery of what one really desires—what one desires, that is, not in one’s daydreams but in one’s properly understood situation in reality? From this point of view, to discover one’s true desires would be to transcend a misunderstood self in favor of one’s true self. Or would Lonergan wish to define “self” in some other way that would make it quite distinct from his notion of a “subject”? To pursue such questions, however, would require an exploration of the range of possible meanings of the terms “self” and “subject” beyond any that Lonergan undertook.

Lonergan’s use of the term “existence” in the cited passage is espe-

cially problematic. Here he associates “existence” with “moral self-transcendence,” “self-direction,” and “self-control.” This is not in itself an unclear use—he means that one exists as an ethical agent only when one decides on action and carries it out. But the meaning of “existence” as used in this passage differs perhaps more radically than Lonergan noticed from its meaning in *Insight*, where it has to do with objectively verifiable rather than subjectively enacted existence. It has to do, that is, with existence as experienced and intended from within rather than hypothesized and verified from without.

Reading *Insight* it is difficult not to get the impression that for Lonergan existence is a property specifically of objects and of them only inasmuch as they can be clearly conceived and judged actual by a critical knower. If this were taken to be the normative meaning of the term, however, how could we explain the sense we have that we are already, even before the development of critical self-affirmation of the sort Lonergan described, inextricably involved in existing and are responsible for our success or failure in that project? The type of critical objectivity Lonergan analyzed so effectively in *Insight* is, after all, a late development in the history of mankind, and unless we want to make the claim that no one was properly human before us, it is necessary to find a way of exploring the nature of human consciousness and existence that can take adequate account of the broad range of ways of being human. Lonergan seems to have come to feel this himself as time went on—hence the shift in emphasis in his later works—but he never analyzed his notion of the “existential subject” in anything like the detail of his analyses of what we are doing when we are knowing and what, considered as correlative object, we know when we do it.

There seem to have remained throughout Lonergan’s career two divergent tendencies in his thinking—one based on a scientific and objective model of knowing (what was referred to above as “knowing from without”) and the other a fundamentally different model (“knowing from within”). It would seem to have been the appeal of the latter that made for Lonergan’s continuing interest in, as well as his somewhat perplexed and ambiguous attitude toward, the thought of certain thinkers he liked to call “existential,” probably the most important of whom for him was Eric Voegelin, whose writings both fascinated and perplexed him to the end. Voegelin and the other remaining thinkers to be studied in this book probed more singlemindedly and more deeply

into the subjective or existential dimension of human being than Lonergan did. It remains to be seen, however, to what extent they have succeeded not only in discovering the dimension of depth in subjective existence but also in satisfactorily elucidating it while meeting, as far as it is possible to do so, the demands of critical intelligence that Lonergan so carefully and cogently analyzed.